

The Price of War

In a memory of Sergeant Briggs and Blackhoof Witherspine

The horn sounded in the middle of a victory.

That was the part Blackhoof couldn't reconcile — not the sound itself, which he knew, but the timing of it. The enemy line had just broken. Enemies start running away, one by one, group by group. He could see them, just a few hundred yards ahead, the hobbit ranks dissolving into the kind of retreat that didn't reassemble itself. Scattered shields. Dropped weapons. The particular chaos of men who had stopped thinking about fighting and started thinking about distance.

"Why are they—" he started.

"Don't," said Briggs, on his back.

"But they're running. We have them, the left flank is completely—"

"Blacky." The word came out flat and hard and final. "Don't."

Blackhoof closed his eyes.

Briggs was staring ahead at the retreating enemy with an expression that had nothing to do with the battle anymore. His jaw was set. His hands on the reins were very still, which was worse than if they'd been moving.

Around them, the cavalry was already turning — the mechanical obedience of soldiers who had learned not to think too hard about orders that made no sense. Blackhoof turned with them, because there was nothing else to do, and because the sound of that horn was still sitting in his chest like something that hadn't finished arriving yet.

"Third time in three days," he said, quietly enough that only Briggs could hear.

"Yes," said Briggs.

"Every time we're about to finish it."

"Yes."

"Briggs—"

"I know," said Briggs. "Ride."

He felt the anger the whole way back to camp.

Not in anything Briggs said — Briggs said nothing, which was its own kind of language. But in the set of his shoulders, the quality of his silence, the way he looked straight ahead at the track and didn't see it. Blackhoof had spent enough miles carrying this particular gnome to know the difference between Briggs thinking and Briggs containing something he hadn't yet decided what to do with.

This was the second one.

They came through the camp gate and Briggs turned immediately — not toward their tents, not toward the supply lines, but toward the command cluster at the camp's centre, where the larger tents stood and the senior officers' banners hung limp in the still afternoon air.

"Briggs," Blackhoof said.

"Wait here."

"I don't think that's—"

"Wait here, Blacky." He dropped from the saddle without looking up. "This won't take long."

He walked toward Grix's tent with the unhurried stride of a man who had made a decision and was no longer interested in reconsidering it.

Blackhoof waited approximately ten seconds.

Then he followed.

Commander Grix was a broad goblin who had grown into his rank the way some men grew into old furniture — comfortably, and with no particular intention of vacating it. He had a

soldier's face and a merchant's eyes, and he was in the middle of a conversation with two aides when Briggs walked through his tent flap without announcement.

He looked up.

"Sergeant Briggs," he said, with the measured tone of a man reading the room and not entirely liking what he found there. "This isn't—"

"Three times," Briggs said.

Grix's aides went still.

"Three times in three days we've had them. Twice on the eastern field, once today. Each time the horn sounds at the exact moment the line breaks." Briggs stopped in the centre of the tent. He was not shouting. Somehow that was worse. "Do you want to tell me what we're doing, sir, or would you prefer I work it out myself?"

"Sergeant." The warning in Grix's voice was genuine. "You need to—"

"Because I can work it out myself." Briggs's voice remained level with the effort of a man holding something very heavy very carefully. "I've been doing this long enough. The longer the contracts run, the more the campaign costs. The more it costs—"

"Careful," Grix said quietly.

"—the more profit lands in the right pockets." He met the commander's eyes. "How many today, sir? From our side. How many didn't ride back?"

Silence.

"Fourteen," Briggs said. "I counted. Fourteen of ours, dead on a field we were winning, because someone decided a quick victory is bad for business." His voice finally shifted — not loud, but with an edge that had been sharpened over a long time. "And tomorrow we go out again and too many more will die on ground we already took, because what the hell, the contract pays by the—"

"Briggs." Grix stood. He was taller than he looked sitting down. "That is enough."

"The hobbits have allies to the north. If their reinforcements arrive before we—"

"Enough." The word hit the tent like a closed fist. Grix held the silence for a moment, letting it settle. Then, quieter: "You are a good soldier, Briggs. You have always been a good soldier. But you cannot control your mouth when it is needed, and that is why you are still a sergeant, and why you will never be anything more." He held the look for a moment. "And yes. You've worked it out correctly. Are you satisfied?"

Briggs said nothing.

"Good." Grix turned to his senior aide with the manner of a man resolving an administrative matter. "Ten lashes. Standard discipline for insubordination to a superior officer." He looked back at Briggs without pleasure. "I'd have preferred not to. You didn't leave me a choice."

Blackhoof was outside the tent.

He had heard everything.

He stepped forward when Briggs emerged, and something in his face must have been readable, because Briggs looked at him once and said, very quietly: "No."

"He can't just—"

"He can." Briggs's voice had gone flat again — the flatness of a man who had spent his anger and come out the other side into something colder. "And I knew what I was walking in there to do."

"Then let me—"

"No." The word was final. "There's no reason for both of us to take it. Stand down, Blacky."

Blackhoof looked at him.

Every muscle he had was doing something. His hands were closed at his sides. His weight was forward on his hooves in the way that preceded movement, and the soldiers around them had developed a sudden interest in being elsewhere, and the distance between him and the tent flap was nothing, nothing at all—

He breathed out through his nose.

Slowly. Deliberately. The long, resonant sound of a horse that has been asked to stand still and is making its feelings about that very clearly known.

Briggs stopped.

Something moved at the corner of his mouth.

"Don't," he said, but the flatness had shifted slightly.

Blackhoof held his gaze and did it again — the same slow exhale, weighted with everything he couldn't say, the fate of a creature that has run out of arguments and is left with only the pure expression of its displeasure.

"You're insufferable," Briggs looked at him for a moment longer. Then he turned and walked to the post without another word, and Blackhoof took his position and stood, and did not look away.

The first strike landed and Briggs's hands tightened on the post and he thought: three months. The contract ran out in three months.

Grix's voice in the tent: you will never be anything more.

Fourteen men on a field they'd already won. Tomorrow more. Three months.

The second strike. He exhaled.

The problem — and it was a problem he had been not-thinking about with increasing deliberateness — was not the leaving. Contracts ended, armies moved on, and a gnome with his particular skills could find work without much difficulty. The road had never frightened him. The problem was standing twenty feet behind him, weight forward on his hooves, jaw set, ready to put himself between Briggs and the entire goblin army if the situation called for it and possibly even if it didn't.

Third strike.

The goblins didn't let cavalry go. Not the centaurs — too valuable, too expensive to train. When the contract expired, the rider walked. The horse stayed. And with a new rider usually not that long.

That was how it worked, had always worked, and Briggs had known it since the first morning on the parade ground when a twelve-sided die had rolled one and an eager young centaur had stepped forward with his whole future written on his face.

He had known it then.

He knew it now.

Fourth strike. He focused on his breathing.

The army hadn't broken Blackhoof. Not the battles, not the pink paint, not the ribbon on the saddle strapping, not the slow grinding education of a war that had turned out to be nothing like the stories. He was still looking at horizons. Still asking what was out there. Still — and this was the part that made the arithmetic difficult — trusting the gnome on his back with a completeness that Briggs had spent considerable effort trying not to notice and had failed at entirely.

Fifth strike.

You can't stay, he thought. And you can't leave him here.

Sixth.

He became aware, distantly, of a sound. Familiar. Slow and deliberate and weighted with feeling — the exhale of a horse that has been asked to stand still and is making its objections known to anyone within earshot. No, not a horse, friend!

Something happened to his face.

Seventh strike, and Briggs was smiling — not widely, not warmly, in the small precise way of a man who has been given an unexpected gift and is pretending he doesn't know what to do with it.

Eighth.

You're going to be a problem, he thought, in the general direction of the sound behind him. You have always been a problem. You are going to continue being a problem and I have absolutely no idea what I'm going to do about it.

Ninth.

The sound came again, patient and eloquent and entirely on purpose.

Tenth.

Silence.

Briggs straightened from the post with the careful movements of a man taking stock of his structural integrity, which was intact, more or less, and turned around.

Blackhoof was looking at him. The tension in him had not gone — the forward weight, the closed hands, the expression of a creature that had spent the last few minutes making very deliberate choices about what it was and wasn't going to do. But his eyes were steady, and there was something in them that Briggs recognised and had been trying, for a long time, not to recognise.

Briggs looked back at him.

Three months.

He picked up his coat from the ground where it had fallen and walked toward his friend, and the camp moved around them, and the afternoon light came low and golden through the tent lines, and neither of them said anything at all.

For now, that was enough.

